

Make a Clay Volcano

A bit of a stretch · Either · Grown-up hands-on · Ages 6–10 · 45 min

Brought to you by Mateo — “If it can be stacked, it can be a city.”

Sculpt a clay volcano, rig up a camera to film it, and set off one eruption. Mateo sculpts the mountain, Chike builds the camera rig, and the two ideas turn into one eruption you can film.

WHAT YOU NEED

- Air-dry clay or salt dough
- A small cup or bottle for the crater
- A tray or baking sheet
- Cardboard and tape for the camera rig
- Baking soda, vinegar, and a drop of dish soap

BEFORE YOU START

A grown-up runs the eruption step and handles the vinegar.

Do this on a tray, outside or over a sink. It will spill on purpose.

Nobody tastes anything, even though it looks like a kitchen experiment.

How to make it

- 1 Stand the cup in the middle of the tray. This is the crater.
- 2 Press clay around the cup to build the mountain. Leave the top of the cup open.
- 3 Carve ridges and rivers down the sides with a blunt pencil. Real volcanoes are not smooth.
- 4 Build a simple camera rig from cardboard: a base, two upright sides, and a shelf to rest a phone or tablet on so it points at the crater.
- 5 Put two spoons of baking soda and a squeeze of dish soap into the crater.
- 6 Start recording, then a grown-up pours in the vinegar. Watch the flow instead of the screen.

TALK ABOUT IT

Mateo made the volcano and Chike made the camera rig. What did each idea add that the other one could not?

TRY THIS TOO

Film it a second time from ground level, like a tiny person standing at the foot of the mountain. Compare the two shots.

DID YOU KNOW? · SHAPES & STRUCTURES

Lava is melted rock from beneath the surface. Deep under the ground, rock gets so hot that it turns into a thick liquid called magma. When it finds a way out through a volcano, we call it lava. It cools down and hardens into new rock.